snowmen,' he wrote. 'Many died of hunger; others killed transport camels and oxen for the Muslims to eat the meat and the Hindus to eat the skins! In these extreme circumstances, as in the lowest pit of Hell, all differences of religious practice and taboo were forgotten.'[89] The camp followers who couldn't get access to the dead horses and camels were now seen roasting and spitting pariah dogs in the streets.

Akbar Khan had been released from his prison-pit in Bukhara only a month earlier after a miserable year-long confinement. Shortly before his release, according to Maulana Kashmiri, Akbar had been visited in a dream by a Sufi saint who told him to put on his turban, strap a sword to his belt and go and protect his homeland, which had been given to him by God.[90] Mirza 'Ata, who came greatly to admire the Barakzai heir, learned one version of the story from his followers: 'The 'ulama of the noble city of Bukhara interceded with the ruler Nasir al-Daula to release Sardar Muhammad Akbar Khan and his companions,' he wrote. 'The chiefs of Kabul wrote to Akbar welcoming him, expressing their joy at his liberation and explaining that the English army was much weakened after recent fighting and in no state to resist, so that the Sardar's arrival was most opportune: now was the time for avenging his father, the peerless Amir!' Akbar Khan went straight to Kabul, where all the chiefs and notables told him of the injustices committed by the English, and appealed to him for justice. The Sardar then wrote to Macnaghten asking to see him, and a meeting was arranged.

> The next day, Sardar Muhammad Akbar Khan with some trusted companions rode out from Kabul to the appointed place, as did Macnaghten from the cantonment: they met and embraced heartily and retired for private conversation. This much is reported, that the Sardar told the English envoy that it was no longer appropriate for him to remain in Kabul, that he should hand over one of his officers as a hostage and leave for India. Whenever the Sardar's honoured father, the peerless Amir, was released from foreign incarceration and returned to Khurasan, then the English hostage would be honourably dismissed. Macnaghten agreed, and this agreement was put into writing; the English were all of the opinion that after this agreement there would be no further strife.[91]

The reality was a little more complex. Through Mohan Lal, who remained active within the city, Macnaghten had been in contact with several of the rebel commanders from the very beginning of the uprising and had already for several weeks been exploring the possibility of buying military support, dividing the Afghan factions or engineering some sort of honourable exit.